

Connecticut Mirror Project Video Transcript

3Minutes 14seconds

Angela Eichhorst

Angela Eichhorst 00:00

Hey SDS 410. My name is Angela Eichhorst and I'm a reporter for the Connecticut Mirror. We are a local nonprofit state newsroom that covers the impact of state policy on Connecticut residents. Our reporters cover all sorts of issues from housing stock to equity and education to resources for non English language speakers. And we're looking for your help with a project.

Angela Eichhorst 00:21

Our reporters cover all sorts of issues and want to be able to look at historical trends and also compare town by town but they don't know how to use the US 5 year census data estimates. And so we are looking for a dashboard, an app, a website, a tool that helps reporters find census questions to use and compares their story and presents visualizations and a way for them to pull this data into their stories and inform their research as they're working on them.

Angela Eichhorst 00:52

So a couple of things that we would really love to see. It would be great to have a chat bar or method for reporters to find what questions they're looking for. For example, on the topic of housing, there's all sorts of different census estimate questions like how many units are in your house and how many people live there and how old is the house and questions like that.

Angela Eichhorst 01:12

But reporters don't necessarily know all of the data that is available to them to look at that.

So some way for them to really easily see or even with a chatbot to interact to find the data that's going to be the most impactful to their story. Another thing we'd really love to see is some kind of data visualization for reporters to really quickly see trends over time and comparisons between towns. So for example, like how much has this town or how much has Connecticut been building multifamily housing in the last 20 years and the town by town comparison and geographical mapping of that is also really important to us because in Connecticut decisions are either made at the state government level and there's no county governments then they're made at the town level.

Angela Eichhorst 01:57

And Connecticut's actually one of the most inequitable states in the country in terms of there being immense wealth in towns right next to towns that have been just chronically under-resourced for decades. And so being able to make those comparisons is going to be really important too including that in our reporting too. Another thing we'd really love to see is some kind of warning method or even a removal of data that doesn't meet requirements for margins of error.

Angela Eichhorst 02:29

So census data might have only 14 people who answered a question in a town and that might not be enough to make an accurate analysis claim on that town. So some way that this tool could warn or even remove that so that the data remains high quality and a reporter might not be able to spot that that margin of error is an issue at that point.

Angela Eichhorst 02:53

So in terms of languages, I'm most comfortable in R and Python and I really don't mind between which one. But if there's, if there's another language that you think would be really advantageous to use in this tool we're also open to that too and we're really excited to work with you and looking forward to seeing what you create. Thank you so much.